

5D Mark 2 refresh rumours

Experts feel a Canon 5D Mark 3 is coming soon. Specs include a 26.4 MP FF sensor, 4.9 fps, 19 point AF system and 100% coverage

Camera prices rise

The calamity in Japan has affected even grey market camera prices, and all cameras have experience hikes of around 5 per cent

Camera test

dial. Aperture and shutter speed also get dedicated dials, the rear dial works as an aperture control in manual mode.

Both cameras are solidly built although the G12 also has an articulating LCD – a nice plus. The G12 also gets a lot of dedicated controls namely dials for aperture and shutter speed in manual mode. It's nice to see buttons that are wedge shaped according to the orientation of your thumb i.e. the ones below the rear dial slope downwards while the ones beneath it slope upwards, which is exactly how your thumb touches them. In terms of usability both Nikon P7000 and Canon G12 are much better than many of the basic cameras, if manual control is your thing.

The S95 is a slightly different beast. It actually has a lens ring that can be configured to change one from among a number of settings on the fly. The S95 is smaller than either of the other cameras, but offers a rugged aluminium chassis and a slimmer profile. Zoom is only 3.8x, while RAW mode is supported as an attraction to those who like to tweak their images using editors. The lens on the S95 goes down to f2 at the wide end – pretty useful for shooting in dim lighting. There is once again a lot of control, even though the S95 has fewer dials, it doesn't seem to miss them much. We had two minor gripes – the top model dial button is positioned where the shutter release button seemed more intuitive for our index finger. And the zoom is a

bit noisy, it almost seems harsh given the smooth action on the other two cameras. Additionally, we'd like a zoom range of 5x on the S95, but this wasn't to be. For the record, the P7000 excels here, with a zoom of 7.1x, although zooming on the Canon cameras is a much more intuitive affair.

Performance

There are many aspects to these cameras performance. In terms of zoom, the Canon G12 has the slickest action. In terms of image quality, we're looking at three 10-megapixel sensors, all of them CCD, and once again, it seems like the Canon G12 produces marginally better looking images. While the S95 exposes better at the same shutter, we used a fixed aperture of f5.6 to nullify this and the G12 really produces a clean, artefact free image with lots of fine detail. But neither sensor is perfect. We see the Canon producing marginally more detail in the paper clips, only to fall at par with the other two sensors when it comes to producing details on the flower petals. We see the Canon produce a bright, artificial and detail-less orange, while Nikon produces a faded looking orange, albeit with more detail. Nikon produces a slightly warmer image, with a bit of a yellowish tinge, while Canon produces a visibly cooler image – neither is perfect. The S95 produces an output very close to the G12, although it produces a better, more detailed orange, it loses its composure when trying to reproduce the intricate

details of texture on the flower petals. The Nikon P7000 produces more detail on the paper clips, only to produce a softer looking golf ball, with less sharp looking dimples.

None of these cameras are perfect, and you might wonder why we're nit picking about such minor details when we didn't do so for the cheaper cameras. Well, when you're paying upward of ₹25,000, in lieu of 10,000 bucks, you do expect more right? So do we...

If we had to buy one of these three, which one would we get? Well, their performance was about the same, but with an advantage in terms of optical zoom, and a lower price tag, the Nikon P7000 is hard to beat. It wins our coveted Best Buy and is the camera to get for the discerning clicker.

PROSUMER INTERCHANGEABLE LENS: WHEN A DSLR IS TOO BIG

So, you've owned that compact point-n-shoot for three years now, and have gone mighty comfortable with manual control. Aperture, exposure and metering are not Greek to you, and you fancy yourself a hotshot photographer, but you need a new, better set of tools. Well, not quite ready for a dSLR? Don't want something bulky and un-concealable to go with your slick lifestyle? But you demand quality. You might want to take a look at the two cameras we've got here. They both feature

detachable lenses and can be used with different lenses much like dSLR cameras. They even have manual controls, and one of them even has a very capable dSLR sensor.

But wait, if so, then what good are dSLRs? Well, these cameras are good, but let's face it – they're no Nikon D700 replacement, and if you need a dSLR, buy a dSLR. In our opinion, professionals and serious hobbyists will still opt for a dSLR, for these cameras haven't quite reached those levels of quality, but if you're looking for a good compact camera, these will pretty much offer the highest per pixel quality you'll likely see.

Closing thoughts

There's been a lot happening in the camera world, as technology has been steadily improving. There's been talk of mirror-less systems taking over dSLR cameras, but for the moment, we feel this is hogwash – dSLRs have too developed an ecosystem and too much money has gone into their development, although we admit that the flip-up mirror does take up a lot of space. This time round, we had a good bunch of cameras, even the more affordable ones offered decent results. The more expensive cameras offered proportionately better features, while we're finally seeing the upper echelon of compact cameras raising the bar of performance and closing the gap between themselves and lower-end dSLRs. However, such cameras are still a far cry from the full frame monsters and premium lenses that we see as part of the tools made available to professionals by the likes of companies like Canon, Nikon and Sony. The important thing here is that paying a lot less doesn't get you rubbish, and all said and done, if you're on the lookout for a compact clicker, you are spoiled for choice. **1**

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